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THE GAMECOCK

PUBLISHED WEEKLY BY THE LITERARY SOCIETIES OF THE UNIVERSITY OF SOUTH CAROLINA

Vol. II

COLUMBIA, S. C., NOVEMBER 13, 1908

No. 6

S. C. UNIVERSITY 19
GA. MED. COLLEGE

Carolina Was in Rare Form Played a Pretty Game.

ON-SIDE KICK A FEAT

Murdaugh Made a Ninety-Five Yard Run For a Touchdown.

In Augusta on November 4, the team walloped the Georgia Medical College team in their second gridiron battle with a score of 19 to 5. Last season the same team was defeated on the same grounds by a small margin, and this year's game was a pleasant surprise to us all.

The teams seemed quite matched at the opening of the game, though Georgia was much heavier along the line. After a short time, Georgia got the ball on a fumble and made a spectacular run of 95 yards for a touchdown. This put Georgia into the Carolina men and Georgia was "easy meat" from them on.

However, Georgia's back field let up in their playing, and consistent gains also scored a touch. J. A. Brown made a perfect forward pass to W. W. Brown for a 20-yard gain. The backs also made considerable gains around our ends. Cline again scored a touchdown during the remainder of this half.

In the second half Carolina superb ball. The was used almost ter executed the game. The tea- tric machine and into every play. to Georgia's we when Izlar threat safety.

Carolina tried a series of passes and onside kicks beautifully. Georgia seemed less against these dashing plays were the feature of the game. great. Carolina was in mag

**CUT BACK
TREND**
(See page 2)

The **GAMERCOCK**

UNIVERSITY OF  SOUTH CAROLINA
CROWING FOR GREATER CAROLINA

**TRYOUTS FOR
THEIVES CARNIVAL
TODAY**

VOL. LV, NO. 16

Enrolled Students Decrease

As of February 4, USC enrollment had reached 8,538 for the spring semester, 473 less than the comparable figure for the fall term—9,011.

This figure represents registration of on-campus students, those at the five USC centers, and special hospital schools of nursing affiliated with the University. There are also a number of non-credit students and auditors.

The Office of Admissions and Registration processed a total of 917 applications for the spring term. Of this number 676 were admitted—143 new freshmen, 167 transfers, and 366 re-admits.

The College of Arts and Sciences continues to have the largest enrollment with 2,413. The School of Business Administration has 1,555 students.

There are 436 people enrolled in evening school and 927 at the five off-campus centers. Also 136 nursing students are registered in the hospital schools of nursing at Sumter, Orangeburg, Anderson, Spartanburg, Columbia, and Charleston.

century after 1800

Since 1910

1900
FOUNDED 1900

THE GAMECOCK

The University of South Carolina

Monday, April 24, 2006

Vol. 99, No. 91 • Since 1908

VIP offers students ability to buy books

Interne et liste cards bureau

The Daily Gamecock

February 2025

'THIS IS WHAT

Opinion Training

Fall 2025, JC Vaught

J.C. Vaught
(843) 412-5120
Sat & Sun 8AM-12PM



Assistant Editor

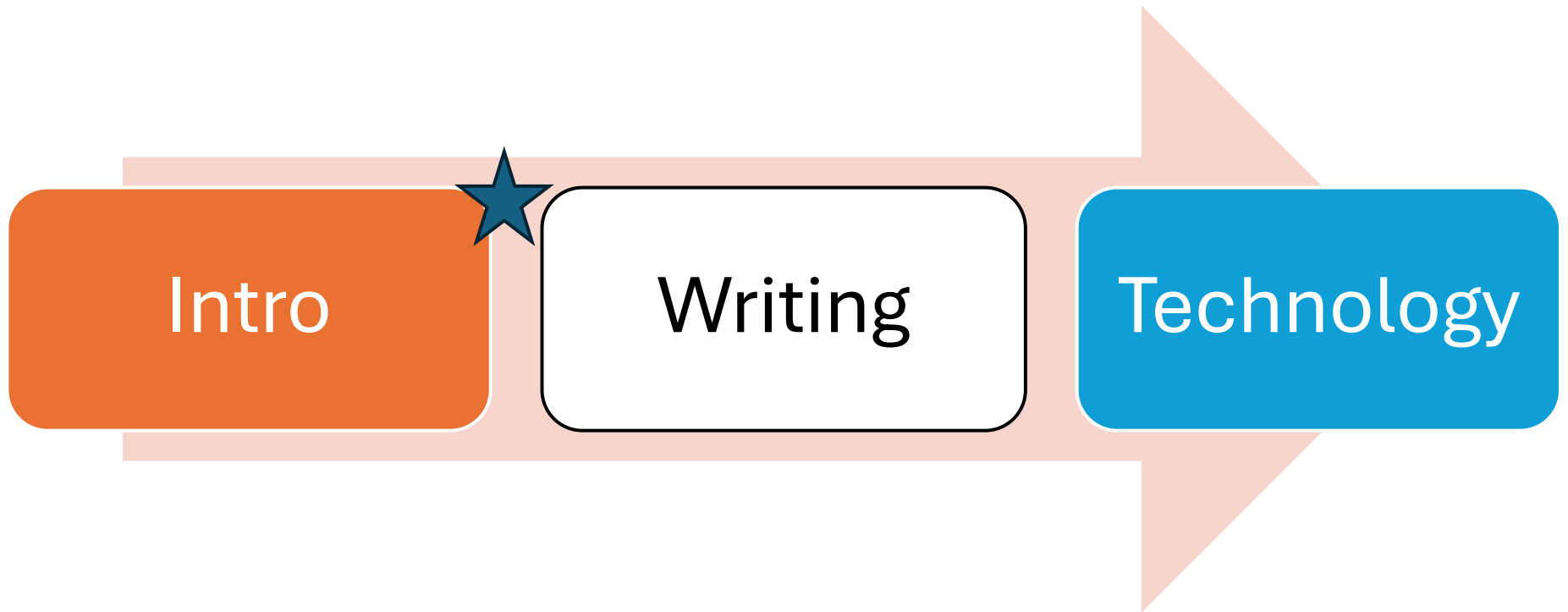
The Editors

Anna McEachern
(339) 215-6474
Mon-Thurs 4-9PM



Editor

Overview – Introduction



Introduction to *Opinion*

The Daily Gamecock, Fall 2025

J.C. Vaught

Full Staff@
2pm

Section@
2:30pm

Newsletter
Fri@9am

Anna hours
4-9PM

J.C. hours
8-12AM

	Calendar	DAY	TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
6 AM							
7 AM							
8 AM	J.C. Office Hours 8:00 AM - 12:00 PM Assistant Opinion Editor						J.C. Office Hours 8:00 AM - 12:00 PM Assistant Opinion Editor
9 AM							
10 AM							
11 AM							
12 PM							
1 PM							
2 PM	Full Staff 2:00 PM - 2:30 PM						
	Section Meeting 2:30 PM - 3:00 PM J School Room 320						
3 PM							
4 PM		Anna's Office Hours 4:00 PM - 9:00 PM Opinion Editor	Anna's Office Hours 4:00 PM - 9:00 PM Opinion Editor	Anna's Office Hours 4:00 PM - 9:00 PM Opinion Editor	Anna's Office Hours 4:00 PM - 9:00 PM Opinion Editor		
5 PM							
6 PM							
7 PM							
8 PM							

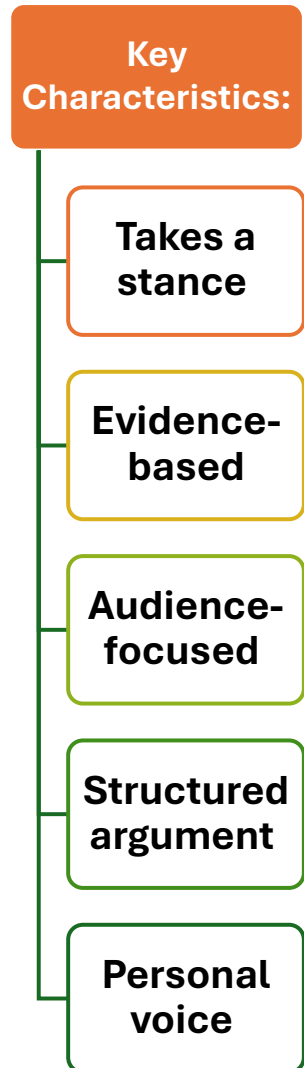
What is an Opinion Column?

Definition: An article where the author states a clear opinion on an issue and provides evidence

The Goal: Convince your readers to think differently, *take action*, or understand an issue from your perspective while providing them the evidence to support that viewpoint.

What Makes It Different:

- Unlike news articles: You're not neutral; you're advocating for a position
- Unlike personal essays: You need sources and evidence, not just personal experience
- Unlike academic papers: Accessible language, engaging tone, shorter format



Examples of Columns at TDG

Column: College is becoming unaffordable for students

Column: South Carolina's roads need serious attention

Column: Disney live-action remakes aren't worth your attention

Head to head: There was no voter fraud in the 2020 Election

Column: Carolina Core should be major specific

Column: American two-party system is fundamentally broken

Column: South Carolina deserves better than Lindsey Graham

Column: If you want real change in this country, vote



Column: AI is a double-edged sword that's getting sharper by the minute

Opinion: Apple innovation is lacking

Column: Stop working toward artificial intelligence

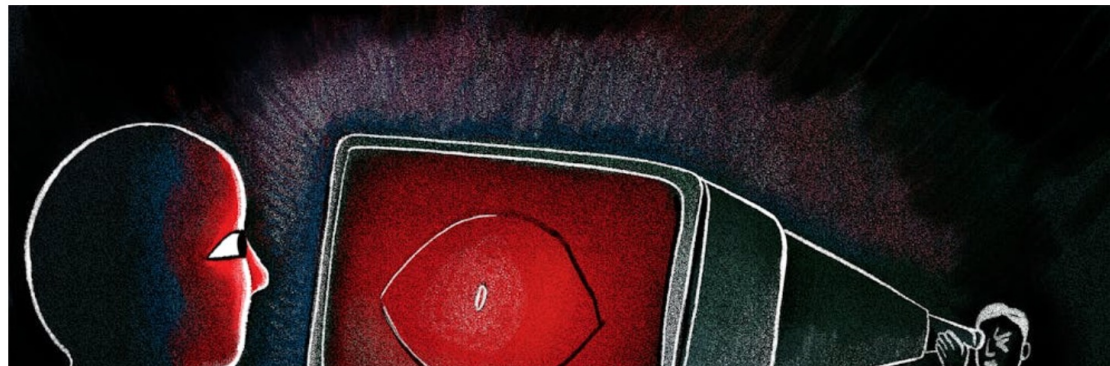
By Nick
October
Be considerate: Turn down your headphones' volume

This s
movie
Odysse
partic
By Cecil
April 8, 2
"Excus
I am t
artific
has be
Matrix
artific
kill us
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Column: Media should livestream presidential debates

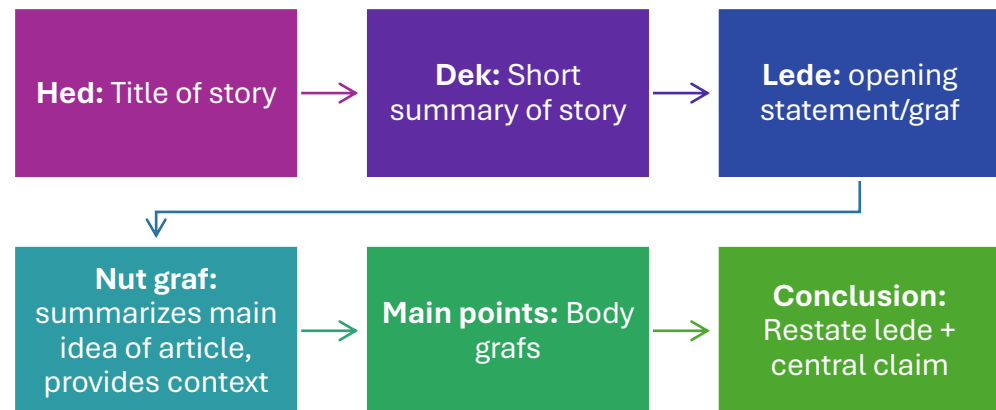
Column: USC's AI policy is unclear. And that's a problem

Column: USC paid \$1.5 million for a tool that can spy on students



Examples of Columns at TDG

Basic Column Structure



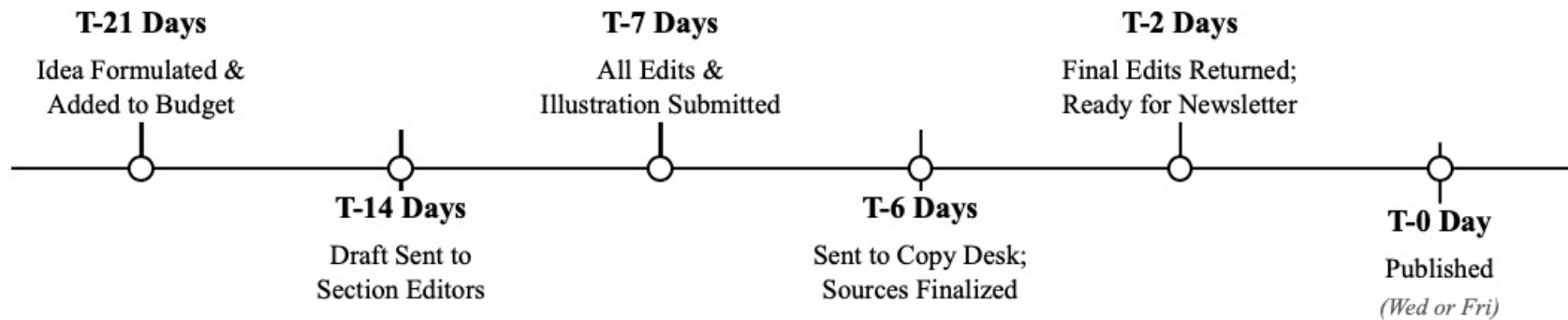
- Online is 600-800 words
- Print is 1100-1300 words

KEEP Audience in mind. Generally, the audience must be USC students/faculty; but up to 25% of pieces can be non-USC.

Timeline of editing

Figure 1: Editorial Production Timeline

A standard 21-day workflow from conception to publication.



This is usually where we need to get statements from USC



Getting to know you!

Main

- Name and hometown(hopefully somewhere i recognize)
- Major and Year – why?
- What is something you're involved with on-campus?
- What's something you know way too much about?

Secondary

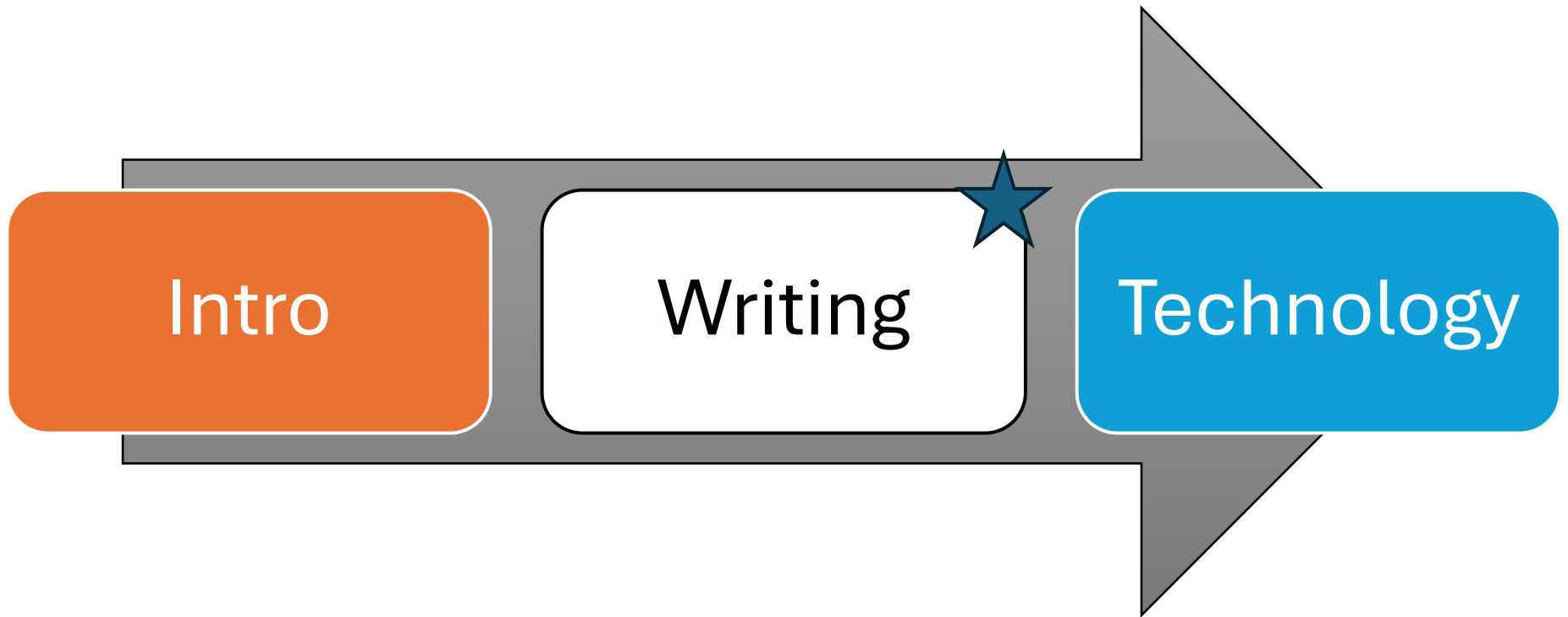
- What's something you thought would be different about college?
- What's one thing (about USC) that genuinely frustrates you?
- What's something everyone seems to love that you just don't get?
- What's your hot take?



Questions for
me?

The background of the slide is dark and filled with numerous question marks of varying sizes and colors, including shades of grey, gold, and blue, creating a sense of depth and focus on the central theme of questions.

Overview – *Writing*



Effectively Writing *Opinion*

The Daily Gamecock, Fall 2025

J.C. Vaught

The *Pre-Writing* Process

Subject

- Start with topics you know already
- Writing about subjects you don't have experience with require more research

Angle

- Develop a specific, arguable position. A contrarian angle is better (imo)
- Know your Audience! (USC faculty, students, staff)

Research

- Find sources to back your angle
- Ideally, you know generally where to look (i.e. website or book)
- Create outline: lede → background → points → quotes → conclusion

The Structure – *Overview*

Lede (First Graf)

- States opinion, introduces topic, shows significance

Nutgraf (Second Graf)

- Provides context and background

Body Grafs:

- Lay out the problem in detail
- Present solution, alternative, or rationale
- Concede valid opposing points, but argue

Conclusion (Final Graf)

- Call-to-action, conclusion, or coda

Paragraph (Graf)

- A "graf" is a short, focused paragraph that contains one complete idea.
- Typically 1-4 sentences and designed to be easily scannable for readers.

Hed (Headline)

- Example: "Column: USC's parking punishes students"

Dek (Subheading)

- 1-2 sentence description of article

Word Count: 600-800 words (700 target)

The Structure – *Headline(Hed)*

Headline Requirements:

- Must state your opinion clearly
- Format: "Column: [Your argument]"
- Be specific, not generic
- Match your lede's position
- Compelling and arguable
- Avoid vague language like "USC has problems"

Strong Headlines:

- "Column: USC's parking policy punishes commuter students"
- "Column: Late-night dining cuts harm student health"
- "Column: Student government wastes money on flashy events"

Weak Headlines to Avoid:

- "Column: Parking is bad" (too vague)
- "Column: Some thoughts on dining" (no opinion)
- "Column: USC needs to do better" (not specific)

The Structure – *Subheadings(Dek)*

Dek Requirements:

- 1-2 sentences maximum
- Expands on or clarifies the headline
- Provides additional hook or context
- Not always required in student papers
- Should entice readers to continue reading
- Can add emotional appeal or urgency

For "Column: USC's parking policy punishes commuter students"

- Dek: "New \$200 fees and reduced spaces force working students to choose between jobs and classes."

For "Column: Late-night dining cuts harm student health"

- Dek: "Thousands of students now go hungry after 10 p.m., when work and study schedules conflict with dining hours."

For "Column: Student government priorities are backwards"

- Dek: "Spending \$50,000 on concerts while cutting food pantry funding shows disconnect from student needs."

The Structure – *Introduction & Lede*(1/3)

The Lede (First Graf)

- Must be a strong, arguable statement
- State your opinion clearly
- Introduce the topic
- Convey why this issue is significant
- Readers should know exactly where you stand before finishing first paragraph

The 4 Ledes

- Straight-News Lede
- Anecdotal Lede
- Scene-Setter Lede
- Direct-Address Lede

The Structure – *Introduction & Lede*(2/3)

Straight-News Lede:

- Directly states news and opinion
- Gets straight to the point
- Clear, declarative statement

Anecdotal Lede:

- Tells story while introducing topic
- Uses specific person/situation
- Draws reader in through narrative

Straight-News:

- "Apartment complexes like The Rowan need to be held accountable for providing dirty apartments and failing to help students find clean, livable spaces."
- "USC's new parking policy punishes commuter students while ignoring real transportation solutions."

Anecdotal:

- "Ashley Gainee walked into her apartment on move-in day ready for the new school year when she came face to face with torn carpet, mold and dog feces."
- "3rd year marketing student Sarah Chen arrives on campus two hours early just to find a parking spot for her 11 a.m. class."

The Structure – *Introduction & Lede*(3 / 3)

Scene-Setter Lede:

- Sets scene for the reader
- Paints a picture of the situation
- Creates atmosphere

Direct-Address Lede:

- Asks question or addresses reader
- Engages reader directly
- Makes issue personal

Scene-Setter:

- "The apartment, supposedly clean and ready to move in, had torn carpet, bugs in drawers and dog feces in a closet."
- "At 10:01 p.m., the lights go dark in USC's last dining location, leaving thousands of hungry students with nowhere to turn for affordable food."

Direct-Address:

- "Have you ever had a dirty apartment on move-in day?"
- "When was the last time you spent three hours looking for a parking spot before your one-hour class?"

The Structure – *Introduction & Nutgraf*

The Nutgraf (Second Graf)

- Grounds the reader with necessary context
- Explains the "so what" factor - why should readers care?
- Efficiently summarize key details: who, what, when, where
- Bridge between your opinion and the evidence that follows

Example

- "Starting this semester, all campus dining locations close by 10 p.m., leaving thousands of students who work evening shifts or study late without affordable food options on campus."
- "The new \$200 parking permit fee, implemented in August, affects over 15,000 commuter students who already struggle with rising tuition costs and limited shuttle services that end at 6 p.m."
- "Last month's student government budget allocated \$50,000 for concert programming while cutting funding for the food pantry that serves 800 students weekly."

The Structure – *Body & Diagnosis*(1/2)

1. Data and Statistics:

- Numbers showing problem scale
- Concrete evidence of impact

2. Quotes from Sources:

- Experts, officials, affected people
- Human voices telling the story

Data/Statistics:

- "Over 2,000 students used the late-night dining services weekly before the policy change"
- "Parking violations increased 300% since the new permit system launched"
- "The food pantry serves 800 students monthly, with demand rising 40% each semester"

Quotes:

- "I've seen more students in my office complaining about hunger than ever before," said Dr. Maria Santos, director of student wellness.
- "We're essentially pricing out the students who need campus resources most," said 3rd-year economics student, James Wilson, who commutes daily.

The Structure – *Body & Diagnosis*(2/2)

3. Anecdotes:

- Short, illustrative stories
- Human face on the issue

4. Reporting Elements:

- Official documents, meeting minutes
- Previous news articles, studies

Anecdotes:

- 2nd year biology student Lisa Chang describes studying until 2 a.m. in the library, then walking to her car on an empty stomach because no food options remained open on campus.
- 1st year Marketing student Tom Rodriguez shows up to campus at 7 a.m. for his 11 a.m. class, spending three hours driving in circles looking for legal parking.

Reporting Elements:

- According to September's Student Senate meeting minutes, administrators acknowledged "unintended consequences" of the dining policy.
- A 2023 study by the National Association of Student Personnel Administrators found that food insecurity affects 38% of college students nationwide.

The Structure – *Body & Prescription(1/3)*

1. The Solution:

- Direct proposal for action
- Explain plan and why it works
- Be specific and actionable

(this is my least favorite ‘prescription’)

Example Grafs

- "USC should extend dining hours until midnight at least two campus locations, funded by redirecting \$75,000 from the current marketing budget."
- "The university must create 500 additional commuter parking spaces in the gravel lot behind the baseball stadium and provide free shuttle service every 15 minutes."
- "Student government needs to establish a \$100,000 emergency food assistance fund, managed through the existing food pantry infrastructure with streamlined application process."

The Structure – *Body & Prescription*(2/3)

2. The Alternative:

- Critique past decisions
- Show better path that could/should have been taken
- Highlight flaws in current approach

Example Grafts

- "Instead of cutting dining hours to save money, administrators could have surveyed students first to understand usage patterns and found targeted cost reductions."
- "Rather than raising parking fees across the board, the university could have implemented dynamic pricing that charges premium rates only during peak hours."
- "The budget committee could have prioritized essential services over entertainment programming, recognizing that hungry students can't focus on campus events anyway."

The Structure – *Body & Prescription(3 / 3)*

3. The Rationale:

- Explain reasoning behind the problem
- Root causes and flawed logic
- Help readers understand "why"

(This is my Favorite type of 'prescription')

Example Grafs

- "These dining cuts stem from administrators viewing food service as a profit center rather than a student necessity, prioritizing budget numbers over student wellbeing."
- "The parking crisis exists because university planning consistently underestimates enrollment growth while overestimating students' willingness to pay premium prices for basic services."
- "Budget decisions reflect a fundamental disconnect between administrative priorities and student needs, with committees making choices based on spreadsheets rather than campus realities."

The Structure – *Body & Counter*(1/2)

Concession:

- Acknowledge valid opposing points
- What would critics say?
- Address their strongest arguments fairly

Example Grafs

- "Critics rightfully point out that extending dining hours would increase labor costs and utility expenses at a time when the university faces budget constraints."
- "Opponents argue that many commuter students could use public transportation or carpool, reducing the need for additional expensive parking infrastructure."
- "Administrators correctly note that emergency food funds require ongoing funding sources and administrative oversight that could strain existing resources."

The Structure – *Body & Counters*(2/2)

Refutation:

- "Yes, but..." approach
 - *(I recommend NOT using 'yes, but...' explicitly)*
- Explain why your position is stronger
- Use evidence to support your case
- **NEVER** give the opposite argument any credibility. I have seen this wayyy too much. **ALWAYS** refute the point made on the other side.

Example Grafs

- "Certainly, extended hours cost money, but the current policy costs students their academic performance. A 2022 study showed that food-insecure students have GPAs 0.4 points lower than their peers."
- "Alternative transportation exists, but Columbia's bus system stops running at 8 p.m. and many students work evening jobs off-campus, making carpooling impossible for many students."
- "Although food assistance requires resources, the university spends more on landscaping than it would cost to feed struggling students. Perhaps landscaping is more important to the university than students."

The Structure – *Closings*(1/3)

Conclusion:

- Restate main point in new words
- Summarize most important evidence
- Ensure consistency with opening

(I usually mix this in with the coda style)

Example Grafs

- "USC's dining policy ultimately forces students to sacrifice their health for the university's budget convenience. When 2,000 students lose access to affordable late-night meals, the administration has failed its most basic responsibility."
- "The parking crisis reveals a university that talks about student success while creating barriers to student attendance. No student should spend more time searching for parking than sitting in class."
- "While the university celebrates record enrollment, its budget priorities show that growth matters more than the students who make that growth possible."

The Structure – *Closings*(2/3)

Call-to-Action:

- Tell readers what to do
- Vote, petition, contact representatives
- Change thinking or behavior

(I hate this closing. too preachy imo)

Example Grafs

- "Students must demand change by attending next Tuesday's Student Senate meeting at 7 p.m. in the Russell House. Bring your meal plan statements and parking tickets as evidence."
- "Contact Provost Johnson at provost@sc.edu and demand a student impact assessment before any future policy changes. Copy your parents on the email; they're paying for services you can't access."
- "Vote in the upcoming student government elections, but only for candidates who pledge to prioritize basic student needs over flashy programming. Your hunger and commute frustrations are policy choices, not inevitable problems."

The Structure – *Closings*(3 / 3)

Coda:

- Reflective final thought
- Memorable anecdote or philosophical point
- Emotional "tail" of your piece

(I usually love these)

Example Grafs

- "Every night at 10:01 p.m., when the last dining location locks its doors, USC sends a message to students: your needs end when our business hours do. That's not the message a university should send to the people it claims to serve."
- "My grandmother used to say that you can judge a place by how it treats the people who have no choice but to be there. By that measure, USC is failing the students who have nowhere else to go at 11 p.m. when they're hungry and studying."
- "A university that makes students choose between eating and sleeping, or between attending class and finding parking, has forgotten that education happens best when students' basic needs are met. Until USC remembers that lesson, it's just a business masquerading as a school."

The Formatting – *Quotes*

First Reference:

- Full name, descriptor with year/major or title
- Always get correct spelling
- Include relevant credentials

Second Reference:

- Last name only
- Use "said" as attribution verb
- Keep it simple

First Reference:

- "Opinion is the best section," J.C. Vaught said, a first-year master's student.
- "Students deserve better dining options," Dr. Maria Santos, director of student wellness, said.
- "The policy creates unnecessary barriers," James Wilson, student body president, said.

Second Reference:

- "Opinion also has the coolest editors," Vaught said.
- "We're seeing real impacts on student health," Santos said.
- "This affects thousands of students daily," Wilson said.

The Formatting – *Dates*

Month Rules:

- With specific dates: Jan., Feb., Aug., Sept., Oct., Nov., Dec.
- Never abbreviate: March, April, May, June, July
- Always spell out when standing alone

Comma Rules:

- Date, month, year: use commas around year
- Month and year only: no commas
- Day and date: no comma needed

Month Abbreviations:

- "January 1972 was cold" (no abbreviation)
- "Jan. 2 was coldest" (abbreviate with date)
- "His birthday is May 9" (never abbreviate May)
- "The meeting is in March" (spell out when alone)

Comma Usage:

- "Feb. 14, 1987, was the target date"
- "May 1986 was a good month"
- "The event is Friday, Dec. 3"

The Formatting – *Numbers & Titles*

Numbers:

- Spell out one through nine
- Use figures for 10 and above
- Always spell out numbers that begin sentences
- Use figures for ages, percentages, years

Titles:

- Capitalize formal titles before names
- Lowercase titles after names or standing alone
- Use courtesy titles (Mr., Ms.) sparingly

Numbers:

- "Five students attended" (spell out 1-9)
- "15 students participated" (figures for 10+)
- "Twenty students filled the room" (spell when starting sentence)
- "She is 21 years old" (always figures for age)

Titles:

- "President John Doe spoke" (before name)
- "John Doe, president of USC, spoke" (after name)
- "The president announced" (standing alone)

The Formatting – *Miscellaneous*

Capitalization:

- Capitalize proper nouns and official names
- Lowercase generic terms
- Course names: capitalize specific courses
- Seasons: always lowercase

Time and Academic Terms:

- Use a.m./p.m. with times
- Abbreviate and lowercase months with dates
- Academic degrees: bachelor's, master's, Ph.D.

Capitalization:

- "University of South Carolina" vs. "the university"
- "Russell House" vs. "the student union"
- "English 101" vs. "an English course"
- "spring semester" (always lowercase seasons)

Time/Academic:

- "The meeting starts at 2 p.m."
- "She earned her master's degree"
- "Dr. Smith has a Ph.D. in biology"
- "The fall 2024 semester begins Aug. 20"

The Details – *Statements & Sources*

MUST Have Sources:

- Any definitive factual claims
- Numbers, policies, specific events
- Direct statements about what happened

MAY Not Need Sources:

- Qualified statements with "appears," "suggests"
- Observations using "seems," "many," "some"

Does NOT Need Sources:

- Personal opinions clearly marked as such
- Generally discouraged / want to minimize

MUST Have Sources:

- "USC is increasing housing prices on students"
- "75% of students experience food insecurity"
- "Parking tickets increased by \$50 this semester"

MAY Not Need Sources:

- "It seems USC is increasing costs"
- "Students appear to be struggling financially"
- "Many students report feeling stressed"

Does NOT Need Sources:

- "I think USC is increasing prices"
- "In my experience, parking is frustrating"
- "From my perspective as a student"

The Details – *Source Quality*

Source Quality Hierarchy:

- Big name media over blogs/personal sites
- Official documents and government sources
- Academic research and studies
- When given choice, choose established outlet
- Original sources better than aggregators

High Quality:

- The State newspaper, CNN, Associated Press
- USC official statements, government reports
- Peer-reviewed studies, .gov websites
- SEC filings, meeting minutes

Lower Quality (Avoid):

- Personal blogs, unverified websites
- Social media posts without verification
- Opinion pieces from unknown sources
- Second-hand reporting without original sourcing

The Details – *Source Guidelines*

What to Avoid:

- Other opinion pieces (unless sourcing opinions)
- Unreliable blogs or unverified social media
- Personal websites over established outlets
- Circular sourcing or echo chambers

Communication Methods:

- In-person/Zoom/phone interviews: Required
- Email statements: OK for University/government only
- Email interviews: Never accepted

Avoid These Sources:

- Random blog posts about campus issues
- Unverified Twitter threads or TikToks
- Other student opinion columns (unless quoting their opinion)
- Wikipedia as primary source

Acceptable Communication:

- Face-to-face interview with professor
- Zoom call with administrator
- Phone interview with expert
- Official email statement from USC Communications

The Details – *Interviews & Expert Sources*

Expert Sources Include:

- Professors with topic expertise
- University administrators
- Student organization leaders
- Students with relevant experience
- Community members with knowledge
- Anyone with specialized knowledge of your topic

For Dining Policy Story:

- Director of Student Wellness
- Campus dining administrator
- Students who work evening shifts
- Nutritionist or food security expert

For Parking Story:

- Transportation services director
- Campus planning administrator
- Students who commute daily
- City transportation planner

The Details – *Interviews & Best Practices*

Left Column - Interview Preparation:

- 5-10 prepared questions minimum
- Research your source beforehand
- Listen actively for follow-up opportunities
- Know their background and expertise
- Plan logical question flow

Interview Methods (Best to Worst):

- In-person interviews
- Zoom/video calls
- Phone calls
- Email: Never allowed

Preparation Questions:

- "What's your experience with this issue?"
- "How does this affect students specifically?"
- "What would you recommend as a solution?"
- "What are the biggest challenges here?"
- "How does this compare to other universities?"

Why In-Person is Best:

- Better rapport building
- Can read body language
- Fewer technical difficulties
- More natural conversation flow

The Details – *Interview Logistics*

Before Interview:

- Ask permission to record
- Test recording equipment
- Confirm meeting time and location
- Review your questions
- Bring backup recording method

Information to Collect:

- First and last name (spelling confirmed)
- Year and major (students)
- Position/title (faculty/staff)
- Pronouns

Recording Permission:

- "I'd like to record this conversation to ensure accuracy. Is that okay with you?"
- Always confirm they understand it's being recorded
- Have backup plan if they say no

Essential Info to Get:

- "Could you spell your last name for me?"
- "What year are you and what's your major?"
- "What's your official title here?"
- "What pronouns should I use?"

The Details – *Interview Logistics*

After Interview:

- Send recordings to copydesktgd@gmail.com
- Review notes while conversation is fresh
- Follow up with thank you message
- Note any promised follow-up information

People You Cannot Interview:

- People you know personally
- Garnet Media Group members
- Friends, classmates, family
- Current professors you have

Email to Copy Desk: Subject: Interview recording - [Story topic] "Attached is my interview with Dr. Smith for the dining policy story. Interview conducted on [date] with permission."

Who You Can't Interview:

- Your roommate (even if they're affected)
- Your professor from this semester
- Your friend who works in dining
- Anyone from Daily Gamecock, SGTV, WUSC
- People in your clubs or organizations



Questions for
me?



Overview – **Technology**

Intro

Writing

Technology



Navigating **Technology**

The Daily Gamecock, Fall 2025

J.C. Vaught

Technology – Artificial Intelligence Usage

AI Policy:

- AI cannot write your entire article
- Final version must be YOUR writing and voice
- Some editing assistance is acceptable
- Research help and planning are encouraged
- Use AI as a tool, not a replacement for thinking

What's Allowed:

- Research assistance and source discovery
- Help understanding complex topics
- Brainstorming angles and approaches
- Grammar and style suggestions
- Fact-checking and verification

Prohibited Uses:

- Having AI write full paragraphs or articles
- Copy-pasting AI responses as your own work
- Using AI to generate quotes or fake sources
- Letting AI make your arguments for you

Academic Integrity:

- Your ideas and analysis must be original
- All sources must be verified independently
- Critical thinking cannot be outsourced

Technology – AI Models

Google Gemini (Best Deal):

- Free for college students for 1 year (Google AI Pro plan)
- Worth \$19.99/month normally

Perplexity AI:

- 1 free month for verified students
- Up to 24 months free through referral program

ChatGPT (OpenAI):

- Free tier with daily limits
- ChatGPT Plus normally \$20/month

Claude (Anthropic):

- Free tier with limited usage
- Claude Pro: \$20/month (no student discount)

Technology – AI Research (1/3)

Start Broad, Then Narrow:

- Ask AI to explain the topic at a high school level first
- Request key terminology and concepts
- Get historical context and current debates
- Ask for different perspectives on the issue

Build Your Knowledge Base:

- "Explain [topic] like I'm new to this subject"
- "What are the main arguments on both sides?"
- "What context do I need to understand this issue?"
- "Who are the key experts I should know about?"

For Complex Issues:

- "Break down the USC parking policy debate into its main components"
- "What are the financial, logistical, and student welfare aspects of dining hour cuts?"
- "Explain the different stakeholder perspectives on housing price increases"

For Background Research:

- "What's the history of similar policies at other universities?"
- "What data would I need to make a strong argument about this?"
- "What questions should I ask experts about this topic?"
- "What counterarguments should I be prepared to address?"

**note that many of these require the 'thinking/reasoning' model to work correctly, or Deep Research functionality. May not be available at free tiers.*

Technology – AI Research (2/3)

When You Have Partial Information:

- "I remember reading about USC's budget cuts affecting dining, but I can't find the source"
- "There was a study about college food insecurity published around 2022-2023"
- "Help me find the official USC statement about the parking policy changes"

Finding Expert Sources:

- "Who are the leading researchers on college food security?"
- "Which USC administrators would be most knowledgeable about dining policies?"
- "What organizations track college affordability issues?"

Lost Source Recovery:

- Describe what you remember: content, publication date, author details
- Ask AI to suggest likely publications or databases
- Use AI to generate search terms you might have missed

Verification Techniques:

- "Help me verify this statistic about student food insecurity"
- "What's the most recent data on college parking problems?"
- "Are there peer-reviewed studies that support this claim?"

**note that many of these require the 'thinking/reasoning' model to work correctly, or Deep Research functionality. May not be available at free tiers.*

Technology – **AI Research (3/3)**

Never Trust AI Blindly:

- AI **WILL** hallucinate sources and statistics
- Always verify quotes and attributions
- Check that links actually work and contain claimed information
- Confirm expert credentials and affiliations

Double-Check Everything:

- Statistics and percentages
- Direct quotes (AI **LOVES** to paraphrase)
- Publication dates and author information
- University policies and official statements

* Also remove the weird utm source thing at the end of URLs from AI. It is a flag that tells the website where traffic comes from – not good for TDG

Technology – Using Slack(1/3)

Notifications Matter:

- Slack is our main form of communication
- Editors send time-sensitive messages
- Assignment deadlines communicated via Slack
- Missing notifications = missing important info
- Mobile and desktop notifications recommended

How to Turn On Notifications:

- Download Slack app on phone and computer
- Allow push notifications when prompted
- Set notification schedule for work hours
- Enable direct message notifications
- Enable mentions and keyword alerts

Mobile Setup:

- Download Slack app from App Store/Google Play
- Allow notifications when app asks
- Turn on badges for unread messages

Desktop Setup:

- Download Slack desktop app
- Enable browser notifications if using web version
- Configure notification timing preferences

Key Channels for Alerts:

- #opinion (your section updates)
- Direct messages from editors
- #full-staff (organization-wide announcements)

Technology – Using Slack (2/3)

Must-Join Channels:

- #full-staff (organization announcements)
- #general (daily conversation and updates)
- #random (casual conversation and community)
- #opinion (section-specific updates and discussion)
- You'll also be added to private group chats with editors

Why Each Channel Matters:

- Stay informed about deadlines and policies
- Connect with other staff members
- Get section-specific guidance and feedback

#full-staff:

- Meeting announcements and reminders
- Important deadline reminders
- Leadership announcements

#opinion:

- Story assignment announcements
- Section-specific deadlines
- Column idea discussions

#general & #random:

- Social connections with other reporters
- Informal updates and chat

Technology – Using Slack (3/3)

Bio Information:

- Profile photo of yourself
- Full first and last name
- Your position (Opinion Writer)
- Phone number for editor contact
- This helps editors identify and contact you quickly

How to Update Your Profile:

- Click your profile picture in Slack
- Select "Edit Profile"
- Upload clear photo of your face
- Fill in all required fields
- Save changes

Profile Photo:

- Clear photo of your face
- Recent photo that looks like you
- Avoid group photos or unclear images

Name and Title Example:

- Name: Sarah Johnson
- Title: Opinion Writer
- Phone: (803) 555-1234
- You can add year/major if you want

This Matters:

- Editors need to reach you quickly
- Helps identify you in large staff

Technology – Recording Interviews

What is Otter.ai:

- AI-powered transcription service
- Records and transcripts conversations in real-time
- **FREE** version available for students
- Works on phone, computer, or web browser
- Automatically identifies different speakers
- Creates searchable text from your audio

Why We Need It:

- Interview transcription saves hours of work
- Ensures quote accuracy for your articles
- Required to send recordings to copy desk
- Backup in case your notes are incomplete

Time Savings:

- Automatic transcription instead of typing everything
- Search function to find specific quotes quickly
- No more rewinding audio repeatedly
- Focus on conversation instead of frantic note-taking

Accuracy:

- Direct quotes captured word-for-word
- Less risk of misquoting sources
- Easy to verify what was actually said
- Copy desk can review exact audio

Technology – Uploading Articles & CEO3

Why Work in Word/Google Docs First:

- More familiar writing environment
- Better spell check and grammar tools
- Easy to save drafts and track changes
- Can work offline without losing content
- Easier to share drafts for feedback
- Less risk of losing work due to technical issues

CEO Is for Final Upload Only:

- CEO is a publishing platform, not writing platform
- System timeouts can cause lost work
- Harder to make major revisions in CEO interface
- CEO best for final formatting and submission

Draft Stage:

- Write complete draft in Word/Google Docs
- Edit and revise until satisfied

Upload Stage:

- Copy and paste final version into CEO
- Add headlines, abstracts, tags in CEO
- Format quotes and check layout
- Message opinion editors

Backup Strategy:

- Keep your Word/Google Doc version saved
- Don't delete original until article is published
- Use this backup if CEO has technical issues



Transition to CEO Slides

Almost done!

Idea Scheduling

- Time to get ideas for you to write about!
- Each of you need to have an idea for 3 weeks from now(latest) so that we can get the ball rolling and get some practice!
- **Column: Publish live capacity for Strom & Blatt — like the library**
Angle: Transparency improves safety & access for disabled students.
Sources: Campus Rec; Student Disability Resource Center; app dev/IT.
- **Column: Greek Village expansion is squeezing club sports**
Angle: Facilities policy favors spectators over student athletes.
Sources: Club sports captains; Athletics facilities; Campus Planning.
- **Column: Bring back the schedule planner**
Angle: Quantify time lost; propose open-source or vendor return.
Sources: Registrar; advising; students who missed classes.
- **Column: USC should subsidize COMET rides for all students**
Angle: Policy penalizes lower-income commuters; compare peer schools.
Sources: COMET official; USC Parking/Transportation; commuting students.

See you next week!